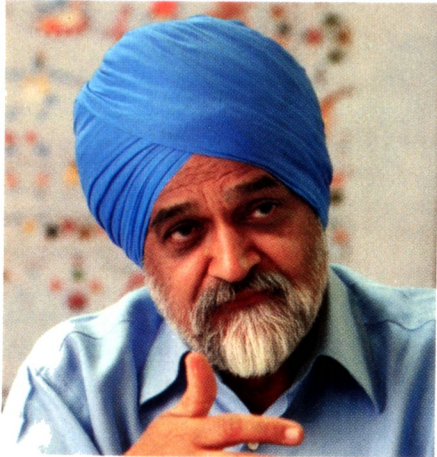


AMIT KUMAR



“The plan is to give a unique identification number which can be used as a base platform which enables all agencies that provide services.”

M.S. AHLUWALIA

DEPUTY CHAIRMAN,
PLANNING COMMISSION

It is more important to secure the database so that it is not compromised,” he said. In fact, officials boasted of best possible security of the existing database which they were building as a National Register of Indian Citizens. “It’s not easy to break into the system since the information can be accessed only through servers placed in the UK and Russia. Also, it is protected by firewalls and seven different algorithms in different places. To break into the system, an intruder will need all the seven algorithms,” he explained.

Playing SAFE A look at the national identification cards abroad

USA

- **Social Security Number**, a nine-digit primary ID number but not meant to be carried at all times.
- **Used to get a job, collect social security benefits, healthcare, open a bank account, obtain a loan, and to join the armed forces.**
- **Facilitates taxation, obtaining driver’s licence and motor vehicle registration.**

UK

- **UK does not have a system of personal ID cards. But they have National Insurance Number (NINO).**
- **A combination of nine letters and digits, NINO is sometimes used for identification purposes but not as a proof of identity.**
- **Issued just before 16th birthday, it is used to administer state benefits and get jobs.**

ate with Nilekani and enable him to meet the 2012 deadline,” disclosed a senior officer in the Prime Minister’s Office. Nilekani, however, might find that creating software is child’s play compared to battling bureaucratic snobbery. Already, his cabinet status notwithstanding, resentment is palpable in the bureaucracy, especially among those handling the MNIC project. They are waiting for Nilekani to join the Government on July 15 to see how he handles the project. Initially, the pilot project was launched with 16 KB memory cards. “There was not much information that could be put in the card since the scope of a smart card is humongous. It was felt that a chip with a 64 KB memory should be used. The MNICs issued to citizens in some coastal areas recently (post-26/11) have 64 KB memory, costing Rs 80 per card,” an MHA official said.

According to him, even this may not be sufficient. With the UID, the Government wants to obviate the need for the multiple identity cards that people carry: ration card, pan card, voter ID, driving licence with none of them providing a foolproof proof of identity. In addition to the basic information like name, date of birth, address, the UID proposes to carry the biometric profile of the person including fingerprints, facial and physical characteristics. It also proposes to include the blood group and allergies, if any, to a medicine in case emergency medical treatment is needed. It wants to add bank details and credit history, along with any arrests or convictions.

Home Ministry officials feel that putting so much data in a card is not feasible. “The trick is to keep adding the information to the database and not load the chip of the card too much.

At this stage even Nilekani himself is not sure whether the MNIC project will be merged with the UID. “The UID will consist of one large centralised depository of each citizen, comprising two kinds of data—the name, address, date of birth, etc and the biometrics,” he told INDIA TODAY. As he sees it, the processes involved are enrolment of a citizen followed by an authentication process. Nilekani said that the enrolment can be done by using any of the existing databases, including PAN cards, passports, MNIC or voter I-cards. For this, verification points will be needed where the citizen can come and provide the biometrics. “It is the authentication process which is important and will ensure that duplication is not possible,” he explained.

Ahluwalia adds that the UID goes beyond the MNIC since it not only serves the purpose of internal security but also ensures that delivery of services and benefits of government schemes like NREGA are diverted to the right people and that there are no pilferages in the Public Distribution System.

It’s an idea whose time has come but whether Nilekani can operate with as much efficiency and productivity in the public sector as he did in the private one, is open to question. Says IT czar Kiran Karnik, “Nilekani has always been interested in public policy but implementation may not be easy with the hard-nosed bureaucracy.” The bureaucracy has this propensity to bury individual identity. ■